

From defense to offense

Over the summer of 1965, the defensive mission of US forces morphed into an offensive one, as ground patrols near US bases ventured further and further afield in active search of the enemy. The shift took place without public debate or even any significant announcement, leaving the vast majority of Americans unaware that a war was coming until it was already well underway.

Johnson administration officials were divided on the issue of escalation, with most arguing that only military force could achieve political results. Others urged caution, saying that President Johnson could choose to “ride the tiger” by going to war against a determined Vietnamese foe, but he could not be certain of being able to choose the place to dismount. Ultimately, the tenacity of the North Vietnamese and Viet Cong would be a deciding factor in the war’s outcome.



Meeting of allies

From left to right, Henry Cabot Lodge, reappointed in 1965 as ambassador to South Vietnam, Defense Secretary Robert McNamara, South Vietnam’s president Nguyen Van Thieu, and prime minister Nguyen Cao Ky at a meeting in Saigon, in July 1965.

“You have a phrase ... **‘riding the tiger.’**
You rode the tiger. We shall.”

LYNDON JOHNSON ON THE US COMMITMENT TO SOUTH VIETNAM, OCTOBER 1967